UNDERCOVER

The right connections

Looking to buy a modem? Agent 001 investigates the relative merits of internal and external modems

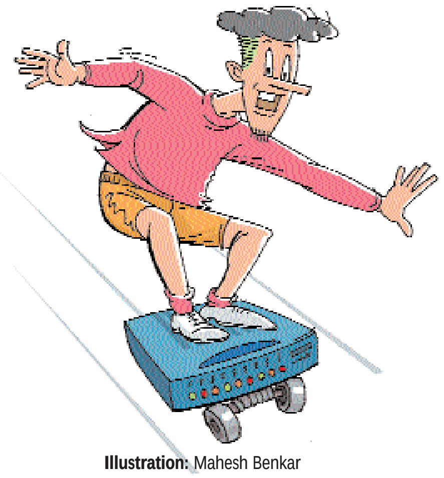

Illustration: Mahesh Benkar

The best thing about external modems is that they are easy to disconnect

The market seems to be increasingly biased towards internal modems, which are sold more and recommended more than external modems. So I decided that an investigation was the need of the hour.

Down to the Mumbai by-lanes. The first vendor I approached was an external modem advocate since "they're much easier to install". That's true; the external modem involves nothing more than getting the cable, plugging it in, and turning it on. You won't have to bother with IRQ conflicts, DMA channels, and the likes. But the dealer, on the contrary, had different statistics in his shop. The last 20-odd PCs that he had sold were all installed with internal modems. His explanation: internal modems have broken the psychological barrier of Rs 1,000 and they work reasonably well, so why not?

Internal modems have become extremely cheap of late and are popular with system integrators as they don't add too much to the overall system's cost. Consumers don't have to pay extra for the fancy case and lights. They also save valuable desktop space and there's no need for cables and power cords.

So what kind of internal modems do these integrators recommend and use themselves? I get a view from another shop in Andheri. The vendor says that he stocks only Dax internal 56K models. The reason: they are priced at Rs 650.

AMR modems are available for Rs 350-500, but then you need an AMR slot on your motherboard for them to work. However, these modems are generally not recommended by most dealers.

However, the number of internal modems which had to be replaced was significant, said the vendor. He added that most users were confused when it came to configuring an internal modem, but once configured, it was a piece of cake.

Strangely, I found that the only vendor who staunchly recommended the external modem was someone who had fried a customer's PC! He narrated a freak incident when during a thunderstorm the internal modem conked out and, in the process, destroyed the motherboard and a couple of other PCI devices. Whether the story is true or not is not the point—the fact remains that internal modems are susceptible to freak cases of lightning strikes on local phone lines which can potentially fry the modem as well as the PC. The same could occur with external modems, it's just that the modem would be destroyed, not the PC.

I then moved on to Santa Cruz where a dealer proudly mentions that he's sold quite a few USB modems. He said that USB modems could work on any PC, Mac, and even workstations, as long as a USB port is present. And one doesn't need an external power supply as the USB cable powers the modem. However, the dealer added that these modems have certain issues when it comes to transfer speeds.

Another vendor recommended the US Robotics Message modem which he found the most reliable in terms of speed and connection. This dealer, more inclined towards external modems, said the best thing about them is that they're easy to disconnect. On many occasions the modem simply stops responding and wastes call time. With an internal modem, the only solution is to restart the entire machine (waste more time), while to reset an external modem, all you need to do is turn it off and then switch it on again. The dealer recommended the DFM 560E 56K external modem from D-Link; it gave him the least trouble with driver installation and configuration.

Another vendor in the same area espoused external modems. His reasoning: since they have lights in front, you can tell what's going on. He recommended the internal modems from Creative and said that they were a bit expensive, but that the component quality was high and the brand name respectable. d

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Modem Hang-ups

Despite the popularity of internal modems there are certain issues that you should be aware of. Internal modems use a sizable amount of CPU time. They also come with a minimum CPU speed requirement and generally cannot be installed on systems with less than 150 MHz processing power.

On occasions, we've found CPU utilisation going as high as 50 per cent on an underpowered machine, which severely impacts the PC's performance. There are some issues with installation too. IRQ conflicts are the primary cause for problems—if you are using an internal modem, try disabling the serial ports to free up some IRQs. Apart from these issues, if you're fairly proficient in installing drivers and solving minor configuration-related problems, then an internal modem is the best and cheapest way to log on to the Internet.